



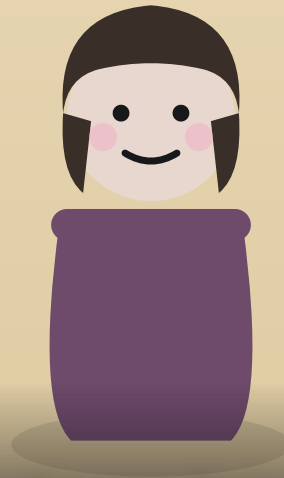
THE LITTLE REWRITES

# THE GIRL WHO FOUND HER WORDS



*A story about a voice that takes its time — and the day everyone finally listened.*

MK PARRISH



In a kingdom that loved a good story  
there lived a girl named Willa,  
whose words took their time.



It was a kingdom built on stories.  
Every year it held the Great Telling —  
a festival where, one by one,  
the people stood in the square  
and told a story,  
and the whole kingdom listened.  
To tell your story well  
was the proudest thing a person could do.



Willa loved stories more than anyone.  
Her head was full of them.  
But when she tried to say them out loud,  
her words took their time.  
The first sound would catch,  
and c-c-catch,  
and stick behind her teeth,  
and she would wait, and try again, gently,  
until it came loose.

*...hurry up...*



And the kingdom, which loved a good story,  
was not very good at waiting.  
People finished her sentences for her.  
They looked away.

Some got a pained, hurrying look,  
as if her slowness were a splinter  
they wished someone would pull out.



So Willa did the saddest thing  
a girl full of stories can do.  
She stopped talking.  
She kept her stories inside,  
where they were safe,  
where nobody could rush them.  
And everyone decided  
Willa simply had nothing to say.  
They were so wrong.  
Willa had *everything* to say.  
She just needed a kingdom  
patient enough to hear it.





Then a strange trouble came.  
At the Great Telling,  
the first teller stood to begin —  
and could not remember her story.  
Nor could the next. Nor the one after.  
A gray forgetting had settled over the kingdom.  
The fast talkers had told their tales  
so quickly, so carelessly, for so many years,  
that they had never really *held* them.  
And now the stories had slipped  
right through their rushing fingers.



The kingdom was in despair.  
A Great Telling with nothing to tell!  
The most wonderful day of the year —  
ruined.



*"...let her tell it. However long it takes."*

And at the very back,  
a quiet voice said, "I remember one."  
Willa's big brother heard.  
He leapt onto a bench and shouted,  
"My sister remembers a story!  
But you have to *let her tell it*.  
All the way. However long it takes."  
The square went quiet.  
Every face turned to Willa.



So Willa stood up.

And she began.

The first word caught, and c-c-caught,  
and stuck behind her teeth.

And here is the thing that had never once  
happened

in all of Willa's life:

*nobody rushed her.*

Nobody finished it for her.

The whole kingdom simply waited —

quiet and still and leaning in —

and let the word come loose

in its own good time.

And it did.





And then the next word.

And Willa began to tell  
the most beautiful story  
the kingdom had ever heard.



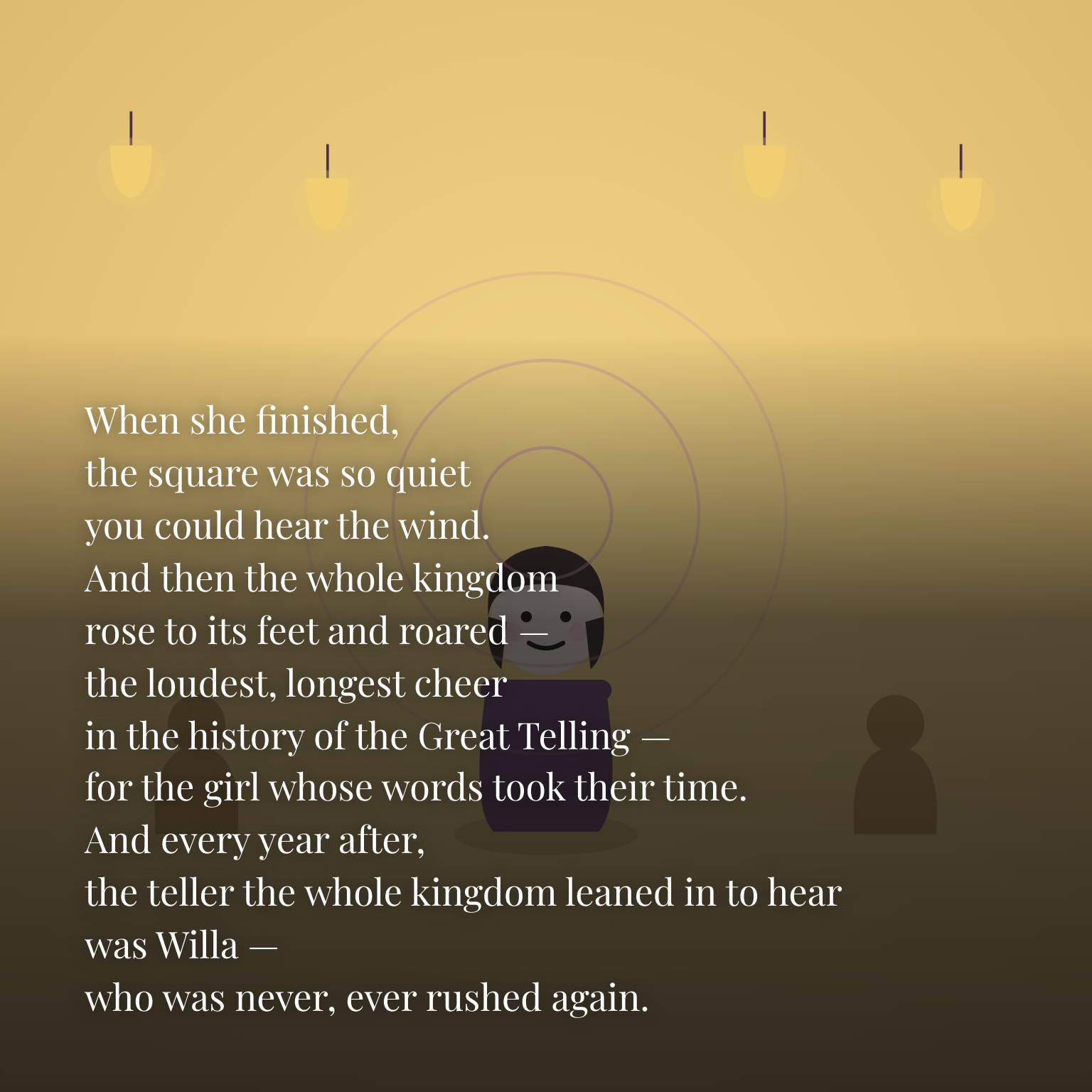
Because here was the secret  
nobody had guessed:  
all those years she wasn't talking,  
she had been *keeping*.

Her words took their time —  
so every one of them  
had been chosen, and polished, and *meant*.  
She did not have less to say.

She had more.

She had been saving it.





When she finished,  
the square was so quiet  
you could hear the wind.  
And then the whole kingdom  
rose to its feet and roared —  
the loudest, longest cheer  
in the history of the Great Telling —  
for the girl whose words took their time.  
And every year after,  
the teller the whole kingdom leaned in to hear  
was Willa —  
who was never, ever rushed again.



The world is in a terrible hurry.  
But if your words take their time —  
if they catch, and stick,  
and must be coaxed out  
one careful piece at a time —  
hear this:  
your voice is not too slow.  
It is careful. It is chosen.  
It is worth waiting for.  
So take all the time you need.  
The right people will lean in and wait.  
Take your time.  
We're listening.



FOR THE GROWN-UP READING ALONG

The world is in a hurry, and it will try to finish a child's sentences for them — especially a child whose words catch, and stick, and take their time. This is a story for children who stutter or are shy of speaking, and for everyone who loves one. When you finish, read it again unhurried — the way you'd want someone to wait for Willa — and tell the child beside you the truest thing in it: your words are worth waiting for. Take all the time you need.

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